“She's Doing Fine. Why Look at This Now?”

Eight questions families ask about support and backup help, with plain answers and notes on what to bring to a professional.

Your mother is managing well, and you still have questions: who else could help, how you'd ask them, whether it's even your place to bring it up. Here are eight that families ask, answered in general terms.

None of the answers is about your mother in particular. Where a question needs someone who knows her, the answer says who to ask.

1 She's doing fine. Why look at this now?

Because a quiet week is an easy one to talk in, and because nobody has to decide anything. The federal Administration for Community Living says about 80 percent of care at home is provided by unpaid caregivers, family members and friends. Help like that tends to settle into a routine without ever being written down. Writing yours down doesn't mean something is wrong. It lets the family see what it already has. [1]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you find yourself wondering whether the arrangement is enough for her. A page of notes can't answer that; someone who assesses her can.

2 Is it my place to bring it up?

It's her week, so begin with her. AARP's planning guide says every family plan must center on the wishes of the person receiving the care, and should never be made without her participation, knowledge and consent. The CDC's page on care plans says the same: begin the conversation with the person you care for. Show her what you've written and ask what you've missed. [2] [3]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** she would rather not talk about it and you aren't sure how to go on. That is something to bring to your care consultant.

3 Where are the gaps in her support?

Only your own map can show you. Write out an ordinary week, mornings, afternoons, evenings and nights, with who is there or looks in. The blank parts are the times she's on her own, and the names with nobody behind them are the roles with no backup. Both are facts about the week. Whether either one matters can't be read off a page.

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you want to know whether a stretch of time on her own is all right for her. That's a question for the people who know her health.

4 Who could help if the usual person can't?

Possibly more people than the family has thought of. AARP's guide says not to overlook friends, colleagues, clubs and religious or other groups, and that team members need not live nearby or have huge blocks of time to be of value. Write down who might be asked; nobody is a backup until they've said yes. For local resources, the Eldercare Locator, a public service of the Administration for Community Living, connects families to community services for older adults at 1-800-677-1116. [2] [4]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** nobody comes to mind for a part of the week your mother counts on. Put it on your list for your care consultant as an open question.

5 How do we ask someone to be a backup without putting them on the spot?

Ask for something small and specific, and make no an easy answer. The Family Caregiver Alliance notes that when jobs are broken down into very simple tasks, it is easier for people to help. “Could you drive her to the hairdresser on a Tuesday if my sister is ever away?” is easier to answer than “Could you help out?” AARP suggests asking what each person is prepared and not prepared to do. Write down what they said, including the no's. [5] [2] [6]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** the family can't talk about it without old arguments coming up. The Family Caregiver Alliance notes that a third-party facilitator can help when family meetings are difficult.

6 What concerns are worth raising now?

The ones you've seen or been told about, written as what happened: a hand on the wall in the hallway, pills still in the box from a day that's passed. The CDC's brochure for family caregivers says to talk openly with your mother and her healthcare provider about falls, and to show a provider or pharmacist all of her medications, including over-the-counter medicines and supplements. A line with the date is enough. Whether it matters is theirs to say. [7]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** your mother has fallen, tells you she's worried about falling, or seems unsteady. The CDC says to tell a healthcare provider right away.

7 Can we tell from a checklist whether her home is safe?

No. A family can notice things and write them down. It can't certify a home safe, and a printed list can't either. The CDC's home checklist for older adults is a good guide to where to look: stairs and handrails, lighting, floors, kitchen shelves, the bedroom and the bathroom. The same brochure suggests a local community or senior center as a place to ask about fall prevention programs and options for improving home safety. [8]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you've noticed something at home and wonder whether it should change. Describe what you saw to her doctor or to your care consultant.

8 How often should we look at this again?

The CDC suggests updating a written care plan every year, or more often if the person has a change in health or medicines. A family's page can borrow that rhythm, with one addition of ours: look again when anyone on the map has a change in their own life, such as a new job or a move. The Family Caregiver Alliance adds that family meetings need to take place regularly, and that a written note of what was agreed is a helpful reminder. [3] [6]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** her health or her medicines have changed since you wrote the page. Tell her doctor or pharmacist about the change. The page can catch up afterwards.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't answer any question about your mother herself, or say whether her arrangement is enough or her home is safe. Anything that depends on her health, her medicines or her safety needs someone who has assessed her.

Ready for the next step?

You have plain answers to the general questions. The care interview is where the questions become about your mother: it goes through supervision, falls, medication handling, the home and each helper's capacity in a set order, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Administration for Community Living, Who Will Provide Your Care?
2. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families
3. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, Steps for Creating and Maintaining a Care Plan
4. Administration for Community Living, Eldercare Locator
5. Family Caregiver Alliance, Taking Care of YOU: Self-Care for Family Caregivers
6. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting
7. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, Family Caregivers: Protect Your Loved Ones from Falling (STEADI brochure, 2018)
8. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, Check for Safety: A Home Fall Prevention Checklist for Older Adults (STEADI brochure, 2018)